

MODULE 15 / 40

Tufted Titmouse

Baeolophus bicolor

QUICK STATS

Length	5.5 – 6.3 in (14 – 16 cm)
Wingspan	7.9 – 10.2 in (20 – 26 cm)
Weight	0.6 – 0.9 oz (18 – 26 g)
Lifespan	Up to 13 years (avg. 2 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Tufted Titmouse is one of the most charming and acrobatic visitors to eastern feeders — a small, perky bird with a distinctive gray crest, large dark eyes, and a bold black forehead patch that gives it a perpetually alert, wide-eyed expression. It is closely related to the chickadees and shares many of their bold, inquisitive behaviors. Like the Black-capped Chickadee, it readily comes to feeders and is bold enough to take seeds from an outstretched hand with patience. Its loud, whistled song — a ringing "peter-peter-peter" repeated insistently — is one of the most recognizable sounds of eastern woodlands from late winter onward.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Tufted Titmouse is a permanent resident of the eastern United States, from the Great Plains east to the Atlantic coast, and from southern Ontario and New England south to Florida and the Gulf Coast. Like the Red-bellied Woodpecker, it has expanded its range significantly northward over the past 50 years, aided by forest maturation, milder winters, and backyard feeders. It inhabits mature deciduous and mixed forests, forest edges, orchards, parks, and wooded suburban gardens. It shows a strong preference for areas with large oaks and other mast-producing trees.

DIET & FEEDING

- Black-oil sunflower seeds — the clear favorite at feeders
- Sunflower chips and safflower seeds
- Suet cakes — especially valued in winter
- Whole and shelled peanuts
- Acorns, beechnuts, and hickory nuts (cached for winter)
- Insects, caterpillars, and spiders — critical in breeding season

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Tufted Titmice are bold, curious, and highly social birds. Outside the breeding season they join mixed foraging flocks with Black-capped Chickadees, Downy Woodpeckers, and White-breasted Nuthatches, often serving as the "nuclear" species around which the flock organizes. They are dominant over chickadees at feeders, regularly displacing them for the best seeds. Like chickadees, they hammer seeds open by holding them with their feet and striking with the bill. Titmice are avid food cachers, storing seeds and nuts in bark crevices, soil, and leaf litter within their territory for retrieval during winter cold snaps.

NESTING & BREEDING

Tufted Titmice are cavity nesters, using natural holes in trees, old woodpecker cavities, and nest boxes. The female builds a bulky cup nest inside the cavity using leaves, moss, bark strips, and an inner lining of soft material — notably including hair plucked directly from living animals (mammals and even humans). Clutches of 5–6 white eggs with reddish-brown spots are incubated by the female for 13–14 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 15–16 days. Offspring from the first brood sometimes remain as helpers to assist with subsequent broods — a rare behavior in North American songbirds.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Tufted Titmouse's song is a loud, clear, whistled "peter-peter-peter" or "here-here-here" repeated 4–11 times — one of the earliest and most persistent bird songs of late winter, often beginning in January on warm days. It also shares a vocabulary of scolding "dee" calls with chickadees, and the two species understand and respond to each other's alarm calls. A variety of harsh, churring scold notes are given when a predator is detected.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Increasing
----------------	---------------	-------------------	------------

The Tufted Titmouse population is estimated at approximately 8 million individuals and has been increasing steadily, driven by northward range expansion. It benefits strongly from backyard feeders, which have allowed it to survive harsher winters and colonize regions where it was formerly absent. Retaining mature trees with natural cavities and installing nest boxes are effective ways to support local populations.

FEEDER TIPS

- Black-oil sunflower seeds in a tube or hopper feeder are ideal
- Offer a suet cage near large trees — titmice use it year-round
- Shelled peanuts in a mesh feeder attract them reliably
- Install a nest box (1.25-inch entrance) on a tree — they will use it
- Titmice are among the boldest feeder birds — hand-feeding is achievable with patience

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Crest	Gray — tall and pointed
Forehead	Black patch just above bill
Back & wings	Medium gray
Face & throat	White to pale gray
Flanks	Warm peach-orange wash
Bill	Short, stout, dark gray

COLOR ME!

Tufted Titmouse • *Baeolophus bicolor* • Module 15

